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COMMON PYTHON GOTCHAS



Although Python is my favorite programming language, it isn't without flaws. Every language has warts (some more than others), and Python is no exception. New Python programmers must learn to avoid some common “gotchas.” Programmers learn this kind of knowledge randomly, from experience, but this chapter collects it in one place. Knowing the programming lore behind these gotchas can help you understand why Python behaves strangely sometimes.

This chapter explains how mutable objects, such as lists and dictionaries, can behave unexpectedly when you modify their contents. You'll learn how the `sort()` method doesn't sort items in an exact alphabetical order and how floating-point numbers can have rounding errors. The inequality operator `!=` has unusual behavior when you chain them together. And you must use a trailing comma when you write tuples that contain a single item. This chapter informs you how to avoid these common gotchas.